

ANI

UNITED FACE? Ashok Gehlot and Rajesh Pilot with K.C. Venugopal (middle) in Delhi

His die-hard fans think their leader can still pull a surprise. They call his latest overtures a diplomatic move. But a few powerful leaders who switched loyalties between Gehlot and Pilot, and were of late with the younger leader, are feeling let down. "If he gets some post for himself, say Pradesh Congress Committee chief or All India Congress Committee (AICC) general secretary, and leaves his loyalists high and dry, it will further erode his following and credibility," says one such leader.

Contrary to the hype often associated with Pilot's rehabilitation, the Delhi meet ended more as a formality. Almost every participant, reportedly, appreciated the Gehlot government and said they have a chance to return to power. Some expected the rebel leader to hit out at Gehlot, who attended the meeting via video-conferencing due to injuries in his toes. Minister of food and civil supplies Pratap Singh Khachariyawas wanted quick decisions on a few issues as less than three months are left before the poll model code of conduct comes into force. His concerns were reiterated by Rahul and Kharge, who asked Gehlot to not let the bureaucracy dominate his governance and quickly deal with the unfinished agenda. But besides what appeared to be the plain-speak of the two leaders, say most participants, everything went the way Gehlot wanted. They agreed to give party tickets to candidates well in time rather than deferring to the last moment, what Gehlot had said two weeks ago.

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Pilot has apparently softened his stand after the May 30 photo-op with Gehlot at the behest of Rahul, Kharge and Venugopal. Contrary to the ballyhoo created in the media about Pilot launching a party or agitation on his father Rajesh Pilot's death anniversary last month, the event was apolitical.

One of Pilot's aides says having lost his father at 23 and his 'coterie' always making him believe he is cut out only for chief minister, he needed some veteran to handle him with firmness and affection to make him realise the hard realities of politics. This is what Gehlot has always said: Pilot needs to learn to wait for the right moment.

So, where does Pilot go from here? The Congress top leadership does not want to lose a young leader like him provided he is willing to work hard as he did during 2014-2018 but without expecting quick rewards. He may get a post either in the AICC or the apex Congress Working Committee. Moreover, he can be effectively deployed to garner Gujjar votes, even in Madhya Pradesh where the Congress is hoping for a victory. If the party can buck the trend of the incumbent being voted out, Pilot still can hope to be CM at some point in the next five years.

Will Pilot move to the BJP ever? Politics makes strange bedfellows but for now, Pilot appears to be focusing on rebuilding his image as a mature leader of the Congress, willing to put his shoulder to the wheel. ■